



Rusty build-up: India captain Rohit Sharma faces a tricky selection dilemma as most of the squad lacks substantial game-time in ODIs. K. R. DEEPAK

Title favourite, yes, but battle-hardened? Not so much

India has played just nine ODIs since the 2023 World Cup final. Do these numbers suggest **enough preparation** for the Champions Trophy? Let's take a closer look.

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India will head into the 2025 Champions Trophy on the back of one of the leanest build-ups it has ever had for a multi-team event in recent years.

Since its defeat in the 2023 World Cup final to Australia, India has played just nine ODIs — the fewest of any team set to take part in the

Champions Trophy and the second-lowest overall, behind Ireland.

To put it into context, India had played more ODIs (30) than any other team in the 12 months leading up to the previous ODI World Cup. This allowed the team to zero in on the right playing combination, enabling it to embark on a near-spotless run in the tournament.

However, that has not been the case for the upcoming Champions Trophy. Despite playing just nine games, India has used 27 players in ODIs since November 19, 2023 — the third-most by any team.

The lack of selection clarity was evident in the first ODI against England. It began with India's decision to select Harshit Rana over Arshdeep Singh in the playing XI, despite the former not being picked for the Champions Trophy and the